With the decision of Syria to sign the Paris Agreement in 2017, the United States became one of only a handful of countries in the world not to take part in the agreement. Although the US initially signed the agreement under Barack Obama's presidency, his successor, Donald Trump, rejected the agreement, claiming that it asked too much of the United States and too little of other nations. Despite President Biden rejoining the agreement in 2021, in 2025 President Trump once again withdrew the US. This decision struck a blow to the other signatories; as well as having plenty of wealth to fund climate research, the US is also the world's second-largest greenhouse gas emitter. During President Trump's first term in office, he said that he believed climate change to be a natural phenomenon from which the world can "come back" without significant changes to human behavior.

Other nations have voiced their own concerns with the Paris Agreement. The government of Nicaragua, which joined the accord in 2017, criticized the agreement for not going far enough and argued that it will not reduce carbon emissions quickly enough to avert global climate disaster. The Paris Agreement also lacks a mechanism to ensure that countries that have signed it comply with its terms.